

The New York Symphony

FOUNDED 1921 · A NONPROFIT PERFORMING ARTS ORGANIZATION

Board of Directors — Meeting Minutes

Regular Meeting · Thursday, March 13, 2025 · 4:00 p.m. · Hudson Concert Hall, Board Room

Present: Eleanor Vance (Chair), Robert Kim (Treasurer & Finance Chair), Marcus Bell (President & CEO), Patricia Nolan (CFO), and fourteen of nineteen voting directors. **By invitation:** Sofia Klein (Music Director, for the artistic report); a representative of Hartwell Advisory Group (investment consultant). **Absent:** five directors (excused).

1. Call to Order & Approval of Minutes

The Chair called the meeting to order at 4:03 p.m. and confirmed a quorum. The minutes of the December 12, 2024 regular meeting were approved without amendment.

2. President & CEO Report

Mr. Bell reported that the 2024–25 season is tracking ahead of budget on earned revenue, with subscription renewals at 86% and single-ticket sales up 9% year over year. He highlighted the success of the winter festival and the national tour, and noted continued cost pressure from musician compensation and hall operations. He previewed the 2025–26 season announcement scheduled for May.

3. Music Director's Report

Ms. Klein presented the artistic plan for 2025–26, including two world premieres, a Mahler cycle, and an expanded composer-in-residence program. She thanked the Board for its support of the education fellowship initiative.

4. Treasurer & Finance Report

Mr. Kim reported that the organization is operating close to its balanced FY2025 budget of approximately \$48 million. The endowment stood at approximately **\$186 million** as of February 28, 2025. He reviewed year-to-date investment performance and noted that the portfolio modestly trailed its policy benchmark over the trailing year.

Mr. Kim raised two governance matters for discussion:

- The current Investment Policy Statement dates to 2021 and is “due for a thorough refresh,” particularly regarding the limited use of alternatives, the absence of an explicit liquidity framework, and the spending methodology.

- The Finance Committee has, for several years, engaged a non-discretionary consultant (Hartwell Advisory Group). Mr. Kim recommended that the Committee evaluate whether an outsourced chief investment officer (OCIO) model would improve governance, manager access, and accountability, given the staff's limited investment bandwidth.

Motion (carried, unanimous): That the Finance & Investment Committee be authorized to conduct a review of the Symphony's investment governance, including a comparison of the current consultant arrangement with an OCIO model, and to bring a recommendation to the Board no later than the September 2025 meeting.

5. Development Report

Staff reported that the **Centennial Campaign** has raised \$61 million toward its \$75 million goal, with \$40 million designated for the endowment and the balance for the education wing and artistic initiatives. Two leadership gifts are in active conversation. The annual gala, scheduled for April, is projected to net \$3.2 million.

6. Spending Policy Discussion

The Committee discussed the FY2026 endowment appropriation. Under the current 5.0% policy applied to the trailing three-year average, the draw would be approximately \$9.2 million. Given strong campaign momentum and a desire to preserve corpus, the Committee indicated it would likely recommend holding the rate at 5.0% rather than increasing it, and asked staff to model the impact of new endowment gifts on future draws.

7. Other Business & Adjournment

There being no further business, the meeting was adjourned at 5:41 p.m. The next regular meeting is scheduled for June 12, 2025.

Respectfully submitted,

Daniel Ortiz, Secretary to the Board

These minutes are a draft pending approval at the next regular meeting of the Board of Directors.